"In those days this cluster was producing real Madras chequered fabrics for export to Nigeria," says Sekar, the President of the Jute Weavers Association.

After 1970, this cluster began weaving cotton fabric and sarees. Kanchi Cotton dress material sets were woven in the 80's and silk cotton during the 90's. Over the past 10 years, the cluster has completely shifted to natural fibre weaving.

"As a weaver, I was always looking for a breakthrough, something that would make handloom popular, thereby saving it from extinction," says Sekar, adding " The South India Textile Research Association involved us in weaving jute and cotton blended yarn. This set me thinking of developing natural fibre yarn from other sources as well." At that time, a group of students approached him with banana fibre and cotton blended yarn for their project and this added a fillip to his research.

"I developed 25 types of natural fibres and even made it to the Limca Book of Records in 2011 for weaving a saree using 25 different fibres," he says.

Today the Anakaputhur Natural Fibre Weavers Cluster has 25 pit looms and are pioneers in many methods of natural fibre weaving. Collaborating with NIFT students in design intervention and colour combination has enhanced the reach of the products.

Sekar has introduced "MooligaiPudavai" (herbal Sarees) where he infuses natural fibre yarn with turmeric, tulsi, neem and sandalwood. He says, these herbs and spices have anti-bacterial properties and are good for the skin. The weavers have developed 30 different natural fibre yarns so far, of which the most popular are pineapple, aloe vera, bamboo, banana stem and erukkanchedi (Calotropis). Eager to adopt some of these practices, the North East Development council has invited Sekar to train the women weavers of Assam.

"We have finally proved that handloom can be a profitable business," he smiles. This venture has generated more jobs, says Sekar.

Unit 5

Water Shortage

Instructor: 14 of the World's 20 big cities are now experiencing water scarcity or drought conditions. As many as 4 million people already live in regions that experience severe water stress. According to a study in the journal 'Science Advances', nearly half of these people live in our country and with the rising population, this stress is going to mount.

Moderator: I'm happy to introduce two eminent speakers Mr. Ramesh, retired Chairman of Water Management Board and Mr.Joseph, founder of 'The Drop', an NGO. I now request Mr. Ramesh to throw some light on the topic and lead the discussion.

Mr.Ramesh : Humanity is facing water crisis. Either there is too much water in some places or there isn't enough water in other places and we all know that this is being driven not only by climate changes

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